

Cryotherapy for skin cancer

Cryotherapy (also called cryosurgery) removes cancer by freezing it. It is sometimes used for small skin cancers.

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What is cryotherapy for skin cancer?

Cryotherapy uses liquid nitrogen to freeze and destroy cancer cells. It is also called cryosurgery. It is a very quick way of treating:

- some small, low-risk [skin cancers](#), such as a type of basal cell carcinoma (BCC) called superficial BCC
- areas of sun-damaged skin called [actinic keratoses](#) - if left untreated, this condition sometimes develops into squamous cell carcinoma.

Having cryotherapy for skin cancer

The doctor sprays liquid nitrogen onto the area to freeze it. The skin turns white while the area is frozen. It can be painful. Some people describe it as feeling like a bee sting.

You may need more than 1 session of treatment to get rid of the cancer completely.

What to expect after cryotherapy for skin cancer

After treatment, the area may ache or throb for a few minutes.

After about 1 hour, it is common for the area to blister. The blister may become filled with blood and be painful. Your doctor or nurse may need to drain the fluid using a sterile needle. But the top of the blister should be left intact. It will gradually scab over.

About 2 weeks after your treatment, the scab drops off. You may have a scar in the area. This will be paler than the surrounding skin.

You can visit our Online Community [skin cancer forum](#) to talk to people who have been affected by skin cancer, share your experience, and ask an expert your questions.

About our information

References



Below is a sample of the sources used in our skin cancer information. If you would like more information about the sources we use, please contact us at informationproductionteam@macmillan.org.uk

Keohane SG, Botting J, Budny PG, et al. British Association of Dermatologists guidelines for the management of people with cutaneous squamous cell carcinoma 2020. The British Journal of Dermatology. 2021;184(3): 401–414. Available from www.doi.org/10.1111/bjd.19621 [accessed May 2024].

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Sharma A, Birnie AJ, Bordea C, et al. British Association of Dermatologists guidelines for the management of people with cutaneous squamous cell carcinoma in situ (Bowen disease) 2022. The British Journal of Dermatology. 2023;188(2): 186–194. Available from: www.doi.org/10.1093/bjd/ljac042 [accessed May 2024].

Reviewers



This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer. It has been approved by Senior Medical Editor, Professor Samra Turajlic, Consultant Medical Oncologist.

With thanks to: Dr Stephanie Arnold, Consultant; Kerry Jane Bate, Advanced Nurse Practitioner; Dr Philippa Closier, Clinical Oncologist; Sharon Cowell-Smith, Macmillan Advanced Nurse Practitioner Skin Cancers; and Dr Benjamin Shum, Medical Oncologist.

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Our cancer information has been awarded the [PIF TICK](#). Created by the Patient Information Forum, this quality mark shows we meet PIF's 10 criteria for trustworthy health information.

The language we use

We want everyone affected by cancer to feel our information is written for them.

We want our information to be as clear as possible. To do this, we try to:

- use plain English
- explain medical words
- use short sentences
- use illustrations to explain text
- structure the information clearly
- make sure important points are clear.

We use gender-inclusive language and talk to our readers as 'you' so that everyone feels included. Where clinically necessary we use the terms 'men' and 'women' or 'male' and 'female'. For example, we do so when talking about parts of the body or mentioning statistics or research about who is affected.

You can read more about how we produce our information [here](#).

Date reviewed

Reviewed: 01 September 2024 | Next review: 01 September 2027

Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information](#).

How we can help

Macmillan Support Line

The Macmillan Support Line is a free and confidential service for people living with and affected by cancer. If you need to talk, we'll listen.



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

Get help